

Handshake

Investor Memo

Company: Handshake · **Product:** Handshake Agent

Stage: Pre-seed bridge

Raising: \$100,000 · \$20,000 minimum check

Date: 17 June 2026

The ask

We're raising a **\$100,000 pre-seed bridge** to build Handshake Agent and complete the regulatory groundwork to operate as a licensed crypto service in Nigeria. Terms: **15% equity for \$100,000** (≈\$667K post-money), **\$20,000 minimum check**, allocated pro-rata. The bridge takes Handshake to a working MVP, a supervised regulatory standing, and a closed pilot — the milestones that set up the seed and licensing round.

Problem

Nigerians transact in crypto at some of the highest rates in the world — to hedge a depreciating naira, to save in dollars, and to move money across borders. Yet the on-ramps are exchange-style apps that make people learn a new interface, manage an account, and trust an unfamiliar surface. The channel nearly every Nigerian already lives in — WhatsApp — isn't where they can act, because platform policy keeps crypto transactions off it. There's a gap between where users are and where they can transact.

Solution — Handshake Agent

Handshake Agent is a conversational financial assistant. Users talk to it in plain language — in any language — to buy, sell, swap, send, and receive crypto, and to find and buy event tickets. WhatsApp is the front door for discovery, questions, and support, with a smooth handoff to a companion web app where verification and money movement happen and which serves as the system of record. The experience feels like chatting with a knowledgeable assistant; underneath, every transaction runs through a deterministic, compliance-checked execution engine, so fund movement is always validated, confirmed, and authorized.

Handshake is multi-product by design: the same conversation that on-ramps a user can sell them a concert ticket. That lifts engagement and revenue per user without raising acquisition cost.

Why now

- **Adoption.** Nigeria is among the top crypto markets globally, with durable structural drivers — inflation, currency depreciation, remittances, and a young mobile-first population.
- **Regulatory clarity.** ISA 2025 made the SEC the VASP regulator and opened the ARIP incubation pathway: a supervised route to operate and grow toward full registration with

a lower near-term capital requirement. Early, compliant entrants build a lasting advantage.

- **Channel fit.** WhatsApp's ubiquity makes conversational acquisition efficient, and Meta's policy supports awareness, Q&A, support, and linking users to a site to transact — exactly the model Handshake runs.

Market

Framed bottom-up: the serviceable opportunity is Nigerian retail crypto on/off-ramp volume plus event-ticketing spend, monetized at a low-single-digit take rate. A conversational, multilingual product distributed through WhatsApp can win share on experience and distribution. The fiat footprint extends across Africa later through our processor's multi-currency reach.

Business model

Three revenue streams, modeled conservatively:

1. **FX spread — 1–2%** (base case 1.5%) on fiat ↔ crypto conversion, priced at or below the parallel rate to stay competitive. With the official rate around ₦1,360/\$ and the street rate around ₦1,400/\$ as of mid-June 2026, a ~1.5% spread is both viable and competitive.
2. **Processing fee — 1–3%** on transactions, net of payment-processing and network costs.
3. **Ticketing commission — 1–5%** of ticket face value, earned as merchant of record.

Profitability is driven by transaction frequency and a structurally low, WhatsApp-led acquisition cost. The second product (tickets) and repeat on/off-ramp behavior are the compounding levers.

Go-to-market

WhatsApp for acquisition and engagement; the web app for conversion and retention. The conversational hook lowers the barrier versus an app install, and ticketing deepens the relationship. We instrument CAC, activation, and repeat rate from the first pilot.

Competition

Nigerian crypto on/off-ramps are an established, competitive category. Handshake's edge is the conversational, multilingual, multi-product experience distributed through WhatsApp — meeting users where they already are, with less friction, and earning across more than one product. We compete on experience and distribution, and build accordingly.

Regulatory strategy

ISA 2025 makes crypto services to Nigerian users an SEC-regulated activity, and Handshake is built to operate inside that perimeter:

- Enter the **ARIP** supervised pathway near-term — a lower capital bar at the Approval-in-Principle stage, operating under supervision with a transition to full registration.

- Use the bridge for **groundwork**: local entity, regulatory counsel, ARIP application, and a compliance framework (KYC, AML/CFT, Travel Rule, reporting) built into the product.
- Defer **full statutory capital** and the full registration fee to the licensing round.

Supervised standing also unlocks compliant fiat rails — Nigerian processors work with crypto businesses inside the regulatory perimeter — so entering early is both a compliance and a competitive move.

Traction

Handshake is pre-launch. This bridge funds the MVP and a closed pilot that produces the first real unit economics — onboarding conversion, take rate, and repeat behavior — which anchor the seed and licensing round.

Key risks

- **Regulatory timelines** can move; we mitigate by entering ARIP early and building compliance into the product from day one.
- **Rail access** depends on regulatory standing, which is why ARIP comes first and unlocks compliant fiat rails.
- **Channel** risk is contained: WhatsApp is acquisition-only, while the web app holds all funds, history, and execution, so Handshake is resilient to any platform change.
- **Execution safety** is architected in: no model output moves money — a deterministic engine validates and executes every transaction after explicit confirmation and step-up authentication.

The raise

\$100,000 pre-seed bridge. 15% for \$100,000 (≈\$567K pre-money / \$667K post-money), \$20,000 minimum check, allocated pro-rata:

Check size	Equity (pro-rata)
\$20,000	3.0%
\$30,000	4.5%
\$40,000	6.0%
\$50,000	7.5%
\$60,000	9.0%
\$70,000	10.5%
\$80,000	12.0%
\$90,000	13.5%
\$100,000	15.0%

Use of funds:

Category	Allocation	Purpose
Product & engineering	\$40,000 (40%)	MVP: web app core, agent + execution engine, WhatsApp layer
Regulatory & legal groundwork	\$20,000 (20%)	Entity, counsel, ARIP application, compliance framework
Infrastructure & integrations	\$15,000 (15%)	WaaS, payment processor, on-chain, ticketing pilot, hosting
Go-to-market	\$15,000 (15%)	Pilot acquisition, onboarding, growth experiments
Operations & contingency	\$10,000 (10%)	Working capital, treasury buffer, runway

On instrument. The structure follows how the round fills. An investor taking the full \$100,000 receives the 15% equity stake, issued immediately. Investors taking part of the round — any check below \$100,000 — come in on a SAFE with a \$667K valuation cap (the same post-money valuation), converting to equity at the next priced round at the ownership shown in the table above. The economics are identical either way; the SAFE simply defers share issuance and keeps the cap table clean while several smaller checks come together.

What this bridge buys

- A working MVP: WhatsApp acquisition layer plus a web app with KYC, wallets, NGN ↔ crypto buy/sell, send/receive, PIN and beneficiaries, and one ticketing integration.
- An ARIP application in motion and a compliance framework in place.
- A closed pilot producing the first unit economics — the evidence base for the seed and licensing round.

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